

aban news

Anti-Hype

How solopreneurs put AI to work without the bullshit

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Don't read it cover to cover like homework. Jump to the chapter that solves today's problem. The later chapters are the workshop: templates to copy, one fully worked day, and a tool-by-task overview.

Why this eBook exists

Most AI guides sell you a feeling. This one doesn't.

Since 2024 I've written a daily newsletter about AI for people who make money with it — not talk about it. Along the way I've tested hundreds of tools, deleted dozens, and noticed: most of what gets sold as a “2026 must-have” solves a problem you don't actually have.

This eBook is the distilled version for one person: the solopreneur whose day has 24 hours and who won't waste any of them on tool demos.

An example I see often: someone buys a 200-dollar subscription to an “AI content system” because a video promised 30 posts a week. Three weeks later there are zero posts — because the problem was never the writing, it was the missing decision about what to write at all. No tool on earth makes that decision for you.

What you will NOT find here

- Prompts that supposedly “automate your business” but really just produce a nice paragraph.
- Tool lists with 50 entries, 47 of which you'll never open.
- The promise that AI makes you rich while you sleep.

How to use this eBook

Six short chapters, each readable on its own in under ten minutes. Read the one that hits today's problem, try a single thing, and come back when the next question shows up. Knowledge you don't apply is just consumption that got more expensive.

What you will find: a way of thinking that separates substance from show — and a few concrete routines that save hours.

The 3-question bullshit filter

Before you take an AI tool, course or trend seriously, run it through three questions. If it survives all three, it's worth a second look.

1. What exactly does it replace?

Not “what can it do”, but: which concrete task you do manually today disappears? If the answer stays vague, it's show. If it's concrete, it's substance.

Test: describe the task in one sentence that starts with “Instead of X, I now do Y.” “Instead of typing every receipt by hand, I photograph it and have the data extracted” is concrete. “It makes my bookkeeping smarter” is marketing.

2. What does it cost me when it's wrong?

AI hallucinates. Always. The only question is how expensive a mistake is. Proofreading a draft post costs 30 seconds — delegate it. Copying a tax figure unchecked costs real money — verify every line.

Sort your tasks roughly into two buckets: reversible and expensive-irreversible. A headline that falls flat you fix in minutes — let AI hand you ten variants. A newsletter sent to 4,000 people with a wrong number can't be pulled back. The more expensive the mistake, the more of your own checking it deserves.

3. Does it work without me — or with me?

“Fully automatic” is almost always a lie. The tools that actually carry their weight are accelerators: you stay the head, AI does the dull work in between.

The most common thinking error

Most people ask “what can this tool do?” and get impressed by the long answer. The better question is “which single task from my week does it reliably take off my hands?” One tool that truly does one thing beats ten that do everything a little.

AI is an intern with a perfect memory and zero judgement. Treat it that way — and you'll rarely be disappointed.

Your minimal AI stack

You don't need 20 subscriptions. You need four building blocks.

1. One good language model (required)

Claude or ChatGPT, paid tier. Your workhorse for writing, sorting, summarising. One is enough — learn it properly instead of constantly switching.

The roughly 20 to 25 euros a month for the paid tier is rarely the issue: if it saves you one hour a week, it has paid for itself on day one at any realistic hourly rate. What's actually scarce is your time to learn to drive it well — not the budget.

2. An automation hub (optional)

Make.com or n8n. This is where you glue services together. Only add it once you genuinely do a task manually three times a week.

3. A place for your knowledge

Notion, Obsidian, whatever — as long as it's searchable. AI is only as good as the context you give it.

Concretely: keep a simple text file with your audience, your tone, your three most common tasks and a few phrasings that sound like you. Paste that block at the top of every longer job. The difference between a generic answer and one that sounds like you is almost always just this context — not the model.

4. GDPR clarity (non-negotiable)

Before you dump customer data into a tool: where are the servers? Is there a data-processing agreement? A GDPR breach costs more than any productivity gain.

Do: anonymise what you don't need — “client A in industry B” is plenty for a draft proposal. Don't: paste whole mail threads with real names, addresses and contract details into some random free tool just because it's handy right now.

Rule of thumb: process first, tool second. Whoever starts with the tool goes looking for a problem to fit it.

Five routines that actually save time

No magic — just routine work you delegate.

- **Pre-sort your inbox:** AI drops mails into three buckets — now, later, ignore. You still decide.
- **Turn one long-form into three formats:** one input, several outputs. You edit instead of starting from zero.
- **Write proposals faster:** a template plus the key facts, AI builds the draft. 45 minutes become 10.
- **Bundle research:** one clear brief with a sources requirement — then check the sources yourself.
- **Mirror your own week:** AI as a sober mirror, not a coach throwing confetti.

One routine walked through

Take the proposal. Instead of starting with a blank document, you keep a fixed template: greeting, deliverable, scope, price, timeline, next step. You hand AI only the five key facts of this case plus the template and let it fill the draft. Then you read it once, fix the price and the tone — done. The thinking (what does this cost, what am I promising) stays with you; only the typing and formatting fall away.

Realistically that's closer to saving about half the time than the “10x” jump from the ads — and only after you've built the template cleanly once. It sounds unspectacular, but over a year it adds up to whole working weeks.

Every routine keeps you as the final instance. AI delivers the raw material; your judgement makes the product.

Seven hype traps

- **Tool-collecting addiction.** Ten half-learned tools are slower than one you've mastered.
- **The autopilot myth.** “Runs by itself” usually means “breaks by itself when you're not watching”.
- **Prompt packs for €47.** A good prompt is a clear task — you can write it yourself, for free.
- **Vanity output.** Reach without substance is still emptiness.
- **AI as a strategy substitute.** A model won't decide for you who you want to be.
- **Blind trust in numbers.** AI confidently states statistics it invented.
- **FOMO as a business model.** Whoever scares you about missing out is selling you the cure too.

How to spot a hype trap

Three warning signs almost always show up together: a deadline (“today only”), a round number with no source (“saves you 20 hours a week”) and a promise that takes your work away entirely instead of speeding it up. When all three sit in one ad, you can click it away fairly safely.

That doesn't mean ignore everything. It means wait for the second wave. What's still being shared after four weeks because it genuinely helps people — and not just because it was new — has earned your attention. The rest you can miss without harm.

The uncomfortable truth: many who talk loudly about AI earn their money from the talking — not from the AI.

Where to go from here

If you've read this far, you already have the most important skill: patience for substance over the reflex for hype.

This eBook is a snapshot. AI changes weekly. What stays is the mindset: ask concretely, weigh the risk, judge for yourself.

Your first step this week

Don't pick five things — pick one. Take the single task that felt most like dull repetition this week and try exactly one routine from chapter 4 on it. Roughly measure how long it took before and how long now. That one honest comparison gets you further than ten tool lists you've read.

That's exactly what I do every weekday in the newsletter — the three AI developments that affect your business today, in five minutes, no bullshit. No deadline, no pressure, unsubscribe any time.

Subscribe for free: abannews.com — thanks for reading. — Aban

Templates to copy

Seven building blocks you paste straight into your language model. Replace the placeholders in square brackets and it runs.

One rule first: the more context sits at the top of the job, the less you fix afterwards. Always say who you are, who the text is for and in which tone — otherwise you get the average of the whole internet.

1. Summarise a long document

- **Summarise the following text in at most five bullet points.** Add one sentence on what I concretely need to do or decide. List open questions separately. Invent nothing that isn't in the text. Here is the text: [PASTE TEXT]

2. Turn notes into a post

- **Turn these raw notes into a LinkedIn post for [AUDIENCE].** Tone: sober, no hype, no chains of exclamation marks. The first line must spark curiosity without overselling. Max 1,200 characters. Notes: [NOTES]

3. Draft a proposal

- **Write the draft of a proposal.** Structure: greeting, the task in one sentence, deliverable, scope, price, timeline, next step. Factual, no sales talk. Key facts: client [INDUSTRY], task [TASK], price [AMOUNT], delivery by [DATE].

4. A cold email that doesn't read like spam

- **Write a short cold email to a [ROLE] at a company in [INDUSTRY].** Max 90 words, one concrete reference to their business, a single call to action (a 15-minute call). No flattery, no buzzwords. My offer: [ONE SENTENCE].

5. Shorten a text without losing the point

- **Cut the following text in half.** Keep the core message and the numbers, drop filler words and repetition. Same tone as the original. Text: [TEXT]

6. Find counter-arguments before others do

- **I claim: [YOUR THESIS].** Give me the three strongest counter-arguments and a short answer to each. Be hard, not polite — I want to see the gaps before a client finds them.

7. Pre-draft an email reply

- **Draft a polite, clear reply to the following email.** My goal: [WHAT YOU WANT TO ACHIEVE]. Short, friendly, without grovelling, same level of formality as the original. Email: [INCOMING EMAIL]

Save the two or three templates you need weekly as text snippets. A template you can't find again is one you won't use.

A day, walked through

A realistic Tuesday for a freelance copywriter — once without, once with AI. No invented miracle number, just an honest sum.

Maria is a freelance copywriter with five clients. Her Tuesday has three recurring blocks: the inbox, one client proposal, one blog post from notes. Here is how it ran before, and how it runs now.

Before: the manual Tuesday

- **Inbox (40 min):** read 30 mails one by one, sort, answer three.
- **Proposal (50 min):** blank document, rethink the structure, hunt for phrasings, format.
- **Blog post (90 min):** turn twelve bullet points into 800 words, reorder twice.
- **Total: about three hours**, much of it dull setup and formatting.

After: the same Tuesday with AI

- **Inbox (20 min):** AI sorts into “now / later / ignore” and proposes three reply drafts. Maria reads, fixes, sends.
- **Proposal (20 min):** her fixed template plus five key facts, AI fills the draft. Maria checks price and tone.
- **Blog post (55 min):** AI builds a rough draft from the bullets, Maria writes the intro and ending herself and sharpens the claims.
- **Total: about an hour and a half** — the thinking stays with her, the setup falls away.

What keeps the sum honest

That's roughly half the time — not the “10x” from the ads. And the jump didn't come on day one: Maria first needed a week to build her template and context block cleanly. She doesn't pour the saved time into more output, but into two things AI can't do: reaching out to new clients and editing texts more sharply.

Just as important: where a mistake would be expensive — the price in the proposal, the facts in the blog post — she still checks every line herself. The time saving comes from the setup, not from dropping the control.

The gain isn't “more in the same time”, it's “the same quality in less time — and the rest for what only you can do”.

Tool by task

Not “which tool is best”, but “what do I use for which task”. With honest notes on cost and GDPR.

The names below are examples, not paid recommendations. Prices are rough orders of magnitude from early 2026 and change; check the current state before subscribing. There are no affiliate links here.

Writing and editing

- **For:** text, summaries, rewriting, sorting.
- **Examples:** Claude, ChatGPT (both around 20-25 euros a month on the paid tier).
- **GDPR:** check EU data residency and a data-processing agreement; don't enter real client names without need.

Research with sources

- **For:** an overview of a topic, with checkable links.
- **Examples:** Perplexity (free tier available, Pro around 20 euros a month).
- **Honest:** always open the cited sources yourself — “with sources” does not mean “correct”.

Automation

- **For:** connecting services, recurring routines without click-work.
- **Examples:** Make.com (free quota, then from a few euros), n8n (open source, free when self-hosted).
- **Honest:** only worth it from three manual repetitions a week; before that it's tinkering.

Images

- **For:** illustrations, simple graphics, social images.
- **Examples:** Canva (free tier, AI features on the paid plan from around 12 euros a month).
- **Honest:** check rights and trademarks; don't use generated images blindly as your own brand.

Transcription and notes

- **For:** turning conversations, voice notes and calls into text.
- **Examples:** Whisper (open source, free locally), various web services (often from around 10 euros a month).
- **GDPR:** get consent for client calls; local processing is friendlier for data protection.

The rule above all: start with one good language model. Only when the same task there regularly takes too long is a second, specialised tool worth it.

One tool you've mastered beats five you've merely installed. Extend the stack only when a concrete task forces you to.